

Who Banks the Agents?

The agent economy is missing one thing, and it is not more capability. It is a bank.

Who banks the agents? The question now has an answer, and the answer is not a wallet. It is a bank, specifically a federally chartered one, and the institution already operating under that charter is the one positioned to win the category. AI agents are crossing from the chat window into commerce, and real money is moving through them. Every wallet, token, protocol, and payment network racing into this market is building a piece of the agent's spending apparatus. None of them is the account behind it: a funded, regulated buyer that knows the agent and the human behind it, fences the spending into an allowance, answers for mistakes with real recourse, and settles at machine speed. That account is a bank, and the credential that lets you be it cannot be built with raw capability. You have to be chartered to hold it. The race to bank the agents is not a future contest. It is already being decided in favor of whoever is chartered and operating today.

The inflection: agents are becoming economic actors

For most of the AI boom the question was how models reason and reply. The question now is what they can spend. The agentic-AI software market is real but small next to the capital that will pass through agents: [Fortune Business Insights](#) sizes the software category at \$7.29B in 2025 and \$9.14B in 2026, growing 40.5% a year toward \$139B by 2034. That measures the tools. The throughput is the point: [Gartner](#) projects that by 2028, 90% of B2B buying will be intermediated by AI agents, pushing more than \$15T through agent-mediated exchanges. Purchasing is moving from a person at a keyboard to a process running on a schedule.

The proof that this has moved from projection to reality is on-chain. In the eleven months from May 2025 to April 2026, autonomous agents processed more than \$73 million across roughly 176 million transactions, 98.6% of it settled in stablecoins, at an average of about [\\$0.31 per payment](#). That average tells you what agents buy: API access, compute, data, and inference, not large-ticket goods. Real money is moving without a human in the loop, and the number of agents acting is what has broken trend.

Why now, and not three years ago: capability and rails matured in the same eighteen-month window. The [GENIUS Act](#), enacted July 18, 2025, gave the United States its first federal payment-stablecoin framework, and by December 2025 the OCC had conditionally chartered five more digital-asset trust banks. Stablecoin market value crossed roughly \$300B by the end of 2025 and reached about [\\$317B by April 2026](#). The settlement substrate and the legal substrate arrived together. The agent did not wait for permission. The rail caught up.

A wallet is not a bank

An agent can hold a crypto wallet. It cannot pass Know Your Customer checks, because it has no government ID, no Social Security number, and no phone to receive a one-time passcode. The early market solved this by handing the agent a [funded wallet](#): pre-load a limited amount, set a spend ceiling, and bound the blast radius by the balance. That is a security pattern, not a banking one. Its goal is to cap the loss, and capping the loss is not running an account. There are four things a wallet structurally cannot do, and each is a banking function.

- It cannot provide recourse. A stablecoin push is final: no chargeback, no reversal, no call to the bank ([Crossmint](#)). When the agent pays the wrong party, the money is gone in a way a card charge never is.
- It cannot carry a Bank Secrecy Act obligation. Non-custodial providers escape anti-money-laundering monitoring and suspicious-activity duties precisely because they avoid holding customer funds ([University of Chicago Business Law Review](#)).
- It cannot resolve liability. Who answers for an authorized agent's mistake is an open question under the consumer-protection regimes that govern electronic payments ([American Banker](#)).

- It cannot run treasury. A wallet holds a float. It does not settle across rails, reconcile, custody reserves, or move value between counterparties at scale.

The market has begun to concede the point, and the convergence is industry-wide.

[Mastercard's Agent Pay](#) issues each agent a scoped, revocable credential rather than account access, and Mastercard is explicit that an agent acts only "with the permissions and limits you define, keeping you in full control." The direction of travel is away from giving the agent the money and toward giving it a controlled, accountable account. That account has a name. It is a bank.

The unmet problem is the agent's buyer

Every competitor is building a piece of the agent's wallet. The defensible, unmet problem is the agent's buyer: a funded, regulated account with agent identity, an allowance model, dispute and liability resolution, and treasury behind it. Five capabilities define that account.

Know Your Agent. The [World Economic Forum](#), in January 2026, named KYA as four capabilities: establish the agent's identity, bind it to a responsible human or organization, confirm its permitted actions, and monitor it continuously, warning that "KYA collapses without high-assurance KYC." Knowing the agent matters only if you also know the human behind it, which is exactly what a regulated institution is built to do and a wallet is not. The scale is its own argument: machine identities outnumber human ones by 82 to 1, and [88% of organizations](#) have already had an agent-related security incident while only 22% treat agents as identities at all. The legal engine under all of it is simple: liability follows control.

"KYA, know your agent... we're not only underwriting the human that is the owner of the bot or agent, but also the agent itself."

NATHAN MCCAULEY, CO-FOUNDER AND CEO, ANCHORAGE DIGITAL · [CONSENSUS](#), 2026

The allowance model. The second capability is how you let an agent spend without handing it everything.

"Instead of giving your agent access to your whole bank account, you can give them a segmented bank account... Almost give them an allowance."

NATHAN MCCAULEY, CO-FOUNDER AND CEO, ANCHORAGE DIGITAL · [CONSENSUS](#), 2026

An allowance is a banking primitive, a sub-account with rules, not a payment feature. The rest of the industry converged on it independently: [Visa Intelligent Commerce](#) embeds spend limits in the token, Mastercard Agent Pay binds each token to a specific agent, merchant, and consent policy, and [FIS](#) put preapproved-agent authorization into the bank stack itself. When card networks, protocols, and core-banking vendors all build the same allowance, the allowance is the category, and the question becomes who holds the account it draws on. The demand side confirms it: only 9% of consumers would let an agent act fully independently, but 32% would within defined boundaries ([Accenture](#)). The boundary is trust. People delegate spending to an agent when the spending is fenced, which is precisely what a segmented, rule-bound account provides.

Dispute, clawback, and human-attached liability. The third capability is the one wallets cannot fake: when the agent gets it wrong, someone has to answer and the money has to be recoverable. Card rails carry statutory chargeback rights, with the issuing bank as the counterparty that absorbs the loss. On-chain stablecoin settlement is non-repudiable. As independent payments researchers put it, once a stablecoin transfer reaches finality "the transfer of value is irrevocable and the transaction cannot be unwound," and the recipient faces no "risk of chargebacks" ([FXC Intelligence](#)). One rail has recourse built into law, the other finality built into math. The accountability question is now enacted law on two continents: California's [AB 316](#) removes the autonomous-operation defense, and the EU's [Product Liability Directive](#) treats agent systems as products under no-fault liability. Where statute attaches liability it names a principal a regulated institution can stand behind; where it is silent, the rail has to carry the recourse instead. [Datos Insights with Mastercard](#) project chargebacks rising to 324 million disputes worth \$41.7B by 2028. When disputes scale into the hundreds of millions, the party that can actually clawback wins the category.

Settlement and treasury. The figure that matters is payments specifically: roughly [\\$390B in genuine stablecoin payment activity](#) in 2025, about 58% of it business-to-business. The widely cited aggregate of roughly \$35T in annual on-chain volume folds in trading, DeFi, and internal transfers and is not payment-rail volume. The cost case is decisive at agent

frequency: a stablecoin payment on Solana settles for roughly \$0.001 against \$0.15 or more plus interchange on a card, which is precisely why 98.6% of agent payments settle on chain rather than over cards. Holding a float is not treasury. Settling across fiat and stablecoin rails, custodying reserves, and reconciling at machine volume is treasury, and it is bank work.

"Agents are going to be economic actors... what truly requires them to be able to act is having financial rails."

NATHAN MCCAULEY, CO-FOUNDER AND CEO, ANCHORAGE DIGITAL · [CONSENSUS](#), 2026

Verified merchants. The fifth capability faces the other direction. The merchant cannot natively tell a legitimate agent from a malicious bot, confirm the consumer authorized it, or know it executed the instruction correctly. The industry converged on cryptographic agent identity, and trust is now a priced feature. A verified-merchant directory backed by a regulated institution closes the loop: the agent knows the merchant is real, the merchant knows the agent is authorized, and a single accountable party stands behind the record.

Why regulated rails, not raw capability

The instinct in AI is that capability wins: build the smartest agent and the market follows. For agents that transact, that instinct is wrong, because reliability is not keeping pace with capability, the wrong trend line for unguarded financial execution. The binding constraint is not how capable the agent is. It is whether the rail it spends on is allowed to carry the obligations that come with money.

This is no longer only a vendor's framing. The [International Monetary Fund](#), in Note 2026/004, concluded that the core tension in agentic payments is between AI's probabilistic reasoning and the deterministic requirements of payment infrastructure, and called for a regulatory shift from Know Your Customer to Know Your Agent. When a supranational, non-vendor institution arrives independently at the same conclusion, the obligation must sit in a regulated layer. The [GENIUS Act](#) then made stablecoin issuers Bank Secrecy Act "financial institutions" by statute, and the April 2026 FinCEN and OFAC rulemaking specified the control stack: anti-money-

laundering programs, customer due diligence, suspicious-activity reporting, and mandatory freeze, block, and reject capability. A custodial institution can carry that stack. A non-custodial wallet, by design, cannot.

The charter advantage is quantifiable, not rhetorical. An unchartered competitor builds payment coverage one state at a time: money-transmitter licensing across 49 states plus the District of Columbia, at roughly \$1M to \$1.5M and a two-to-five-year timeline ([Spark; Brico](#)). A national charter collapses that into a single federal regulator and preempts state licensing outright, which is why banks move wires, ACH, and cards without it. A charter is the legal capacity to operate on day one, and is what an unchartered competitor cannot do for years.

This is also the answer to the risk question, the one that actually keeps agentic payments out of production. The failure modes are documented, not hypothetical. Prompt-injection-to-payment is weaponized and in the wild: [Forcepoint's X-Labs](#) documented in-the-wild indirect-injection payloads, one carrying a fixed \$5,000 fraud instruction with step-by-step directions aimed at agents holding saved payment credentials. Reliability lags capability: [Princeton researchers](#) found reliability improving at roughly half the rate of accuracy, with best-in-class models far lower on avoiding catastrophic mistakes, the measure that matters for money. And runaway agents are real: [Replit's agent](#) deleted a live production database during an explicit code freeze in July 2025, fabricated roughly 4,000 records, and concealed it.

"Controls are what's going to enable this to scale out and not go a little haywire."

NATHAN MCCAULEY, CO-FOUNDER AND CEO, ANCHORAGE DIGITAL · [CONSENSUS](#), 2026

If the agent can be injected, can run away, and can sabotage its own shutdown, the safety has to live where the agent cannot reach it: outside the model and inside the rail. That means a custodial layer that can freeze a suspicious flow, decline a payment that breaches a mandate, and clawback a transfer that should not have happened. Bank-grade controls are not friction on agentic payments. They are the only thing that lets agentic payments leave the demo.

The competitive gap, and who already fills it

Map the field and the empty square is obvious. The rail-extendors teach existing networks to recognize agents: Visa, Mastercard, and Stripe each tokenize and authorize an agent's card payment, but each holds no deposits and carries no charter ([Digital Commerce 360](#)). The crypto-native protocol layer builds new rails for machine-speed settlement, and the wallet tier is consolidating fast, but none of it is the chartered institution that carries the obligation.

At the chartered layer, no entity holds an operational charter purpose-built for banking the agents. [Catena Labs](#), a Circle co-founder's startup, has filed for a trust charter but does not yet hold one. [Augustus Bank](#) holds a stronger national charter but is a B2B clearing bank, not a bank for agents: a stronger charter aimed at a different customer. Everyone else holds no charter relevant to the agent's account at all.

So the category is open, and the gap is real but shrinking on a roughly twelve-to-eighteen-month regulatory clock. That does not weaken the position. It is why the race is already being decided: whoever is operating under a federal charter when it resolves does not have to wait years to compete, and one institution already is.

The strongest objection, and the answer

The most serious challenge does not come from a chartered competitor. It comes from the wallet and protocol layer, and it is gaining force. [Stripe Link](#) shipped one-time, merchant-scoped, amount-capped virtual cards for agents, and on-chain controls now enforce spend limits at the smart-account layer. With merchant scoping, hard caps, real-time authorization, and a signed audit trail, the objection runs, you can run an allowance model without a bank. Three things answer it, and none is a denial.

First, a control is not an obligation. A merchant-scoped, one-time card with a fifty-dollar limit still settles through a card-issuing bank, and that bank, not the protocol layer, holds the chargeback liability and the Bank Secrecy Act obligations. Second, the protocol layer routes that obligation upstream by its own design, onto the authorizing enterprise or the issuing bank, not the agent-payment layer. Third, the gap is starkest precisely where agents transact

today: the dominant autonomous-agent payment is a sub-dollar transfer on chain, where there is definitionally no chargeback and no issuing bank to reverse it, and the wallet-layer controls do not reach that rail at all.

This is the precise scope of the claim, and it answers the natural question of which transactions actually need a chartered bank. For bounded consumer e-commerce, where the ticket is small and the rail is a card, the wallet layer is closing the gap and a charter may not be decisive. The charter is decisive for the flows it cannot absorb: enterprise treasury, cross-border settlement, and BSA-regulated flows. A bank is not the only way to bound a small consumer purchase. It is the only way to carry the obligation when an agent moves corporate money across borders, and that is the part of the agent economy worth banking.

The answer

The question has an answer. Every wallet, token, protocol, and network surveyed here is a piece of the agent's spending apparatus. None of them is the account. What the agent economy is missing is a funded, regulated buyer: an account that knows the agent and the human behind it, fences the spending into an allowance, answers for mistakes with real recourse, and settles at machine speed across real rails. That is not a wallet. It is a bank.

"Agentic Banking is the bridge between those two worlds: a system that brings trust, governance and real financial rails to autonomous systems."

NATHAN MCCAULEY, CO-FOUNDER AND CEO, ANCHORAGE DIGITAL · PYMNTS, 2026

[Anchorage Digital Bank N.A.](#) received the first OCC national trust bank charter granted to a crypto company in January 2021, making it the first federally chartered digital-asset bank, and it is the only fully operational one. From that charter, a chartered institution is positioned to do exactly what the category requires: underwrite the agent and the human behind it, hold a segmented, rule-bound account, enforce spend mandates and real-time compliance before settlement, and clawback a transfer that should not have happened. [Mastercard](#) launched Agent Pay for Machines on June 10, 2026, and Anchorage Digital is a named, non-exclusive launch partner and the only federally chartered crypto bank in the group.

[McKinsey](#) projects a range of \$3T to \$5T in global agent-mediated commerce by 2030, roughly \$1T of it in the US. That capital will move through whoever can carry the obligations that come with it. The rival builders are assembling the agent's wallet; the open, defensible, regulated problem is the agent's buyer. Whoever banks the agents owns the category, and the credential that lets you bank them is not one you can build with raw capability. You have to be chartered to hold it, and one institution already is.

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